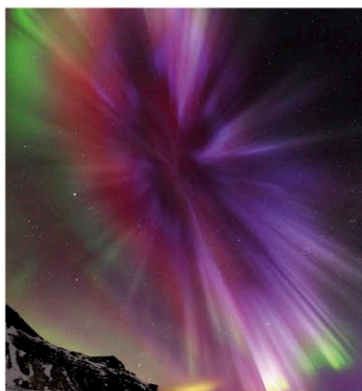
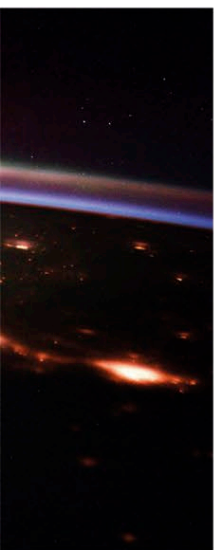




△ AURORA CORONA

The aurora borealis may sometimes appear overhead as a “corona” of rays. This spectacular display was photographed over Iceland.

WHAT CAUSES AURORAE

Aurorae are caused by charged particles (electrons and protons) that speed out from the Sun. Earth’s magnetic field provides a shield against these, but many electrons follow the magnetic field lines toward the poles, where they collide with oxygen and nitrogen atoms and molecules in the upper atmosphere. The electrons excite the atoms, and when the atoms return to their former state, they release energy in the form of photons, which create the dancing patterns of aurorae.

